# How to Stop Using Filler Words (Um, Uh, Like) When Speaking English

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## SEO essentials

| Field | Value |
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| Secondary keywords | stop using filler words, reduce filler words English, stop saying like and uh, speak without fillers |
| Meta title | How to Stop Using Filler Words (Um, Uh, Like) in English |
| Meta description | Too many “ums” and “likes” when you speak English? Here’s why fillers happen and 7 simple techniques to replace them with calm, confident pauses. |
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“Um… I was, uh, like, thinking that…” If your sentences are full of fillers, you’re not alone — and you’re not doing anything wrong. Fillers are your brain buying time while it finds the next word.

The fix is simple to understand, if not instant: **replace filler words with a short, silent pause. A pause sounds thoughtful and confident; “um” and “uh” sound uncertain — but they do the same job of giving your brain a moment.** You don’t need to eliminate every filler (even native speakers use them); you just need to cut the ones that make you sound hesitant.

Here’s why fillers happen and seven practical ways to reduce them.

## Why you use filler words

Fillers aren’t random — they come from three main places:

- **Buying thinking time.** When your brain needs a moment to find the next word, it fills the silence with “um” so the conversation doesn’t feel like it stopped.
- **Nervousness.** Under pressure, fillers multiply. The more anxious you feel, the more “uh” and “like” slip out.
- **Habit.** Often it’s just a reflex you no longer notice — which is why the first step is simply hearing yourself do it.

A few fillers are completely normal and even natural. The problem is only when there are so many that they break your flow and make you sound unsure. Cutting them makes you sound more fluent and confident — even if your actual English level hasn’t changed.

## 7 ways to cut filler words

1. **Embrace the silent pause.** This is the big one. When you’d normally say “um,” just stay quiet for a second instead. Silence feels long to you but sounds confident and thoughtful to the listener.
2. **Slow down.** Fillers spike when you rush. Speaking a little slower gives your brain time to find words without needing to fill the gap out loud.
3. **Record yourself and count.** You can’t fix what you can’t hear. Record a two-minute answer, count your fillers, and you’ll instantly become more aware of them — awareness alone cuts the number.
4. **Breathe at natural stops.** Take a small breath at the end of a thought instead of bridging into the next one with “and uh.” A breath is a clean, invisible pause.
5. **Prepare go-to transition phrases.** Swap “um” for a real phrase that buys the same time: “that’s a good question,” “let me think about that,” “what I mean is.” These sound deliberate, not hesitant.
6. **Speak in shorter sentences.** Long, complex sentences run out of road and force a filler. Finish one short thought, pause, then start the next.
7. **Practise out loud, a lot.** Most fillers come from searching for words. The more you practise speaking, the faster words come — and the less time your brain needs to fill.

## A 5-minute daily drill

This simple loop trains the pause habit fast:

1. Pick a question (“What did I do yesterday?”) and record yourself answering for one minute.
2. Listen back and count every “um,” “uh,” and “like.” Write the number down.
3. Record the same answer again — this time, pause silently wherever you’d normally use a filler.

4. Count again. Watch the number drop.

Do this a few times a week and track your count over time. Seeing the number fall is motivating, and the silent-pause habit starts carrying over into real conversations without you thinking about it.

## Get your fillers counted for you

The hardest part of cutting fillers is noticing them in real time — in the moment, you don't hear yourself say "um." That's where speaking practice with feedback helps. With an AI speaking partner like Yappply, you have a real conversation and get a report afterward that flags patterns like hesitation and filler use, so you know exactly where you're padding. Practising daily, with that feedback loop, is the fastest way to replace "um" with a calm, confident pause — and the more you speak, the fewer fillers you'll need in the first place.

## Frequently asked questions

**Why do I say "um" and "uh" so much in English?** Usually because your brain needs a moment to find the next word, so it fills the silence out loud. Nervousness and habit make it worse. The fix is to replace the sound with a short silent pause.

**Are filler words always bad?** No. A few are natural and even native speakers use them. They only hurt you when there are so many that they break your flow and make you sound unsure.

**How do I replace filler words?** Pause silently instead, slow down, breathe at natural stops, and use real transition phrases like "that's a good question" to buy time deliberately rather than with "um."

**How long does it take to stop using fillers?** Awareness helps immediately — once you can hear your fillers, you start cutting them. Replacing the habit with pauses usually takes a few weeks of daily practice.

**Does speaking slower reduce filler words?** Yes. Rushing is a major cause of fillers. Slowing down gives your brain time to find words without needing to fill the gap out loud.